

VIDYA RAJPUT, 45
TRANSGENDER ACTIVIST
Chhattisgarh

Born Vinay Singh Rajput in 1977 in the Kondagaon district of Chhattisgarh, the third-gender crusader endured decades of abuse as a child and student in her small hamlet of Pharasgaon. "I was not sure of my own identity. I was unable to think like a boy. I felt I was a woman trapped in a man's body," she says. Her effeminate behaviour as a boy made her the target of ridicule. She was often locked up in bathrooms by the boys in her school, was urinated upon and sexually assaulted. Even her own family was bereft of the sensitivity to understand her.

Unable to take it anymore, Vidya fled her village in 1998 to Raipur where she began working as a steward at a hotel. There she met two more stewards who confided in her about their transgender status. They took her to a park in Raipur where members of the community regularly discussed their issues. Vidya heard tales of sexual assault, HIV and rapes. It was then that Vidya decided to start working for their welfare. She quit her job and enrolled with the National AIDS Control Organization (NACO). As a volunteer, she focused on HIV patients among transgenders, which gave her greater insights into the issues of the community. Vidya and her friends set up the Chhattisgarh Mitwa Sankalp Samiti, dedicated to mainstreaming the third gender. Encouraged by other members of her network, Vidya underwent a sex-change operation at a hospital in Puducherry in 2015. Vinay became Vidya at this juncture, one that she describes as the greatest watershed event in her life.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"I plan every day of my life in such a way that it becomes a better day than the previous one in terms of my advocacy work. I feel extremely happy on days when I accomplish my goals"

— VIDYA RAJPUT, Transgender activist

In about eight years of advocacy, Vidya has single-handedly been responsible for securing a number of rights for members of her community. One of the major accomplishments was the setting up of the Transgender Welfare Board in 2015. This has helped the members of the gender secure access to subsidised foodgrains and other government services. A shelter home called Garima Grah has been set up in Raipur where they get a place to stay and are also trained in skills like sewing, computers, henna application and coaching for competitive examinations. Vidya's efforts have ensured that the police have an SOP on treating the members of the third gender in custody. Since 2020, the state police has recruited 22 members from the gender—a first in the history of the country. In addition, there is a 2 per cent quota for them in government-built accommodations.

Vidya has succeeded in making the government and the private sector accept her demand to carry out various male-to-female corrective surgeries for free. Transgenders have also been included in the school curriculum in Chhattisgarh.

"The number of third-gender people is grossly underreported because of the stigma attached to it," says Vidya. "I am working on removing that." Only then will she be able to help others of her ilk to unshackle themselves from the harrowing effects of social exclusion. ■